

## **The Story of the Moon.**

Once, night, unchallenged, extended its dark grace  
across the sky. To the credit of the town, the stars  
at night had been enough, though sometimes  
the townspeople went about bumping their heads  
in sleep. Eventually, three brothers, traveling through  
a foreign town, found an evening that did not  
disappear behind the mountains, for a shining globe  
sat in an oak tree. The brothers stopped. That one  
is the moon, said a man from the foreign town.

The brothers conferred. They could make a certain use  
of it. The brothers stole the moon down and put it  
in their wagon. Seized it. Thieved its silver. Altogether  
greedy. The wagon shining brights. At home:  
the moon delivered. Then, celebration: dancing in red  
coats on the meadow. Number four brother smiling  
wide. The moon installed--it extended its silver  
calculations. Time and more time. The brothers aged,  
took sick, petitioned the town that each quarter  
of the moon, as it was their property, be portioned out  
to share their graves. Done, and the light of the moon  
diminished in fractions. They had extinguished it,  
part for part, and night, unimpeded, fell. Altogether

lanternless. The people were silent. The dark rang loud.

Underground: cold blazing. The dead woke, shivering

in the light. Some went out to play and dance,

others hastened to the taverns to drink, quarrel,

and brawl. Noise and more noise. Noise up to heaven.

Saint Peter took his red horse through the gates

and came down. The moon, for the third time, taken.

The dead bidden back into their graves. One wonders

why a story like this exists.